



Bazaar...make that Mall...with its slew of international brands and the latest gadgets.

What's pushing the frenzied consumer spend is that top global brands are launching their products in India almost simultaneously with global markets. Barely a week after introducing new versions of the iPod in the US, Apple brought them to India, while Nokia's revolutionary Prism models debuted here. Samsung's breakthrough Rs 24 lakh 70-inch HDTV hit the Indian market on September 8, the same day as the rest of the world. The proliferation of brands and availability has also meant that prices are constantly going south. Mobile phones as a genre are more affordable, with new models being launched almost every week. The social buzz, of course, is around Apple's iPhone, which is still to be officially launched in India but is already available in an 'unlocked' version on various online sites. Some functions do not work here but it can make and receive calls and SMS, which is why it's currently the hottest accessory to own.

The iPhone ownership obsession shows that India, like the rest of the world, has succumbed to what psychologists call Technolust, the irresistible desire to possess the latest trendy gadget, no matter what the cost or its utility value. There's a larger issue involved. The cellphone is no longer a technology tool and mobile communicator; it's equally a style statement and extension of individual personality, as are most gadgets these days. The result is excess. Most corporate types now carry two phones, the ubiquitous Blackberry that connects you to your e-mail account, and another, equally expensive one, just to protect their individuality. Our kids are even more prone to technolust. It's rare to see them without iPod earphones lodged in their ears while pecking away on their cellphones, laptops or Playstations.

The lure of technology and the amazing advances in the digital domain have made today's gadgets and gizmos virtually irresistible and the cost almost inconsequential. The bottom line, however, is that Indians have got over their 'imported' hangover, largely because most of the brands are available here and that too the very latest. What's more interesting is that a large percentage of buyers of luxury goods, from Mercedes cars to designer jeweller and expensive gadgets, handheld or home products, are from the non-metro cities located mainly in the north and west of the country. Residents of cities like Chandigarh, Ludhiana, Gurgaon, Lucknow, Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Surat, Pune and Nagpur spend more on luxury goods than those in Mumbai or Bangalore, according to the Knowledge Company's report on Luxury Trends in India.

Brands depend mainly on two hooks: the reputation of the manufacturer and the social status quotient, which is why some have acquired a more iconic image than others. The lines, however, are getting increasingly blurred. Armani and Versace no longer dominate wardrobes as they once did and the same holds true for most other brands. Yet, whatever cutting edge cool that make them the must-have product of the moment. Here's our definitive guide to what's really hot in the India bazaar.